

Discourse Topic Tracking

Many common debates on interpreting Scripture can be safely resolved by applying proper English grammar rules. Take the following, oft debated passage for example.

Exodus 4:20-26

²⁰ And Moses took his wife and his sons, and set them upon an ass, and he returned to the land of Egypt: and Moses took the rod of God in his hand.

²¹ And the LORD said unto Moses, When thou goest to return into Egypt, see that thou do all those wonders before Pharaoh, which I have put in thine hand: but I will harden his heart, that he shall not let the people go.

²² And thou shalt say unto Pharaoh, Thus saith the LORD, Israel is my son, even my firstborn:

²³ And I say unto thee, Let my son go, that he may serve me: and if thou refuse to let him go, behold, I will slay thy son, even thy firstborn.

²⁴ And it came to pass by the way in the inn, that the LORD met **him**, and sought to kill **him**.

²⁵ Then Zipporah took a sharp stone, and cut off the foreskin of her son, and cast it at his feet, and said, Surely a bloody husband art thou to me.

²⁶ So he let him go: then she said, A bloody husband thou art, because of the circumcision.

The primary debate surrounding verse 24 pertains to the antecedent resolution of both pronouns “*him*” (“*the LORD met **him**, and sought to kill **him***”). One view asserts that “*him*” refers to Moses; another asserts it refers to his son.

Why “*him*” cannot be the son

English grammar rules out the son as the antecedent for two reasons:

1. **Agreement in number:** Verse 20 mentions Moses' “*sons*” (plural). The pronoun in verse 24 is “*him*” (singular). A singular pronoun cannot resolve to a plural noun phrase.
2. **Absence of a singular antecedent:** A singular son (“*her son*”) is not introduced into the narrative context until verse 25. A pronoun cannot resolve forward from a noun introduced in a subsequent, separate sentence.

Narrative resumption and discourse tracking

Notice the structural shift between verse 20 and verses 21-23:

- **Verse 20** (narrative action): Moses sets out on the journey.
- **Verses 21-23** (embedded direct speech): The LORD gives Moses instructions.
- **Verses 24-26** (narrative resumption): The narrative resumes from verse 20.

Verses 21-23 suspend the physical timeline to record divine instructions given to Moses **before he left**. In verse 24, the physical narrative resumes. Because Moses is the active subject traveling in verse 20, he remains the active discourse topic when the narrative resumes in verse 24. Therefore, both occurrences of “*him*” in verse 24 resolve **strictly** to Moses. Moreover, the grammar does not permit variability in any of the pronoun resolutions except for the “*his*” in verse 25:

²⁴ And it came to pass by the way in the inn, that the LORD met [**Moses**], and sought to kill [**Moses**].

²⁵ Then Zipporah took a sharp stone, and cut off the foreskin of her son, and cast it at [**Moses/her son's/the LORD's***] feet, and said, Surely a bloody husband art [**Moses**] to [**Zipporah**].

²⁶ So [**the LORD**] let [**Moses**] go: then [**Zipporah**] said, A bloody husband [**Moses**] art, because of the circumcision.

* The grammar permits all three and does not restrict the resolution to any one of them. Therefore, if we want to have a debate, it could only be over this pronoun resolution alone.